5

The End and the Beginning

ASHOKA'S STRUGGLE FOR SUCCESSION ENDED IN OR around 269 BCE when he was consecrated as ruler of the realm carved out by his grandfather and consolidated by his father. The usurper prince took over the throne that he was not meant to inherit, and the large subcontinental empire that came with it, but beyond this his early years as emperor remain an enigma. As before, plausible speculation must serve instead of an empirically strong and convincing narrative because there are neither eyewitness accounts nor any that survive from the years proximate with his own lifetime. As for Ashoka's own testimony, just as he remained silent about his early life and the bloody aftermath of his bid for the Mauryan throne, so he chose not to speak about the initial years of his reign.

Ashoka's early years as emperor came to be recalled in literary texts some centuries later. Those recollections tend to be one-dimensional, as we shall see, ranging from those that see him as an intemperate and violent ruler to others where his persona is that of a searcher for truth. We have no means of telling if these accounts are based on things that Ashoka actually did or are merely retrospective projections of their composers' predilections. My assumption, though, is that some do contain grains of truth. This is suggested by the circumstantial evidence around which allegorical tales of physical violence or spiritual passion were created.

One set of narrations, forming part of what is known as the Northern tradition—the staple for constructing some of the contours of the life of Ashoka as prince—portrayed the early years of his reign as a kind of